

thrives in acidic soils and in wet, boggy ground. It is widely cultivated in the northeastern U.S.

Parts Used Berry (fruit).

Constituents Cranberry contains tannins (catechins, proanthocyanidins, and polyphenols), flavonoids, and vitamin C.

History & Folklore Best known for cranberry sauce, cranberry has traditionally been taken as a tart, acidic drink in Sweden. Cranberry was first cultivated in Britain in 1808 by the English botanist Joseph Banks, and in the U.S.—now the principal grower of cranberries—in the 1840s.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A classic remedy for urinary tract infections, cranberry can be used both to prevent and to treat problems such as cystitis and urethritis. Taken as berries, juice, or extract, it will help to disinfect the urinary tubules and may be taken for problems associated with poor urinary flow such as enlarged prostate, as well as bladder infections. In cases of acute infection, cranberry is likely to work better in combination with herbs such as buchu (*Barosma betulina*, p. 71) and uva-ursi (*Arctostaphylos uva-ursi*, p. 170). Cranberry may also be used long term to prevent the development of calcium carbonate urinary stones.

Research Research published in 1994 found that cranberry juice reduced the need for antibiotics in women suffering from chronic urinary tract infection. It seems likely that cranberry works by making it more difficult for bacteria to cling to the urinary tract wall, and infection is therefore more easily flushed out. The proanthocyanidins and catechins are probably responsible for this action.

Cautions In kidney disease, use only on professional advice.

Verbascum thapsus (Scrophulariaceae) Mullein

Description Upright biennial growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has slightly hairy, gray-green, oval to lance-shaped leaves, and spikes of bright yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Mullein is native to central and southern Europe and western Asia. It is now also naturalized in many other temperate regions. Mullein grows on open uncultivated land and along roadsides. The leaves and flowers are collected during the summer.

Parts Used Leaves, flowers.

Constituents Mullein contains mucilage, flavonoids, triterpenoid saponins, volatile oil, and tannins.

History & Folklore Mullein was once credited with magical as well as medicinal virtues. John Gerard, a 16th-century herbalist, expressed doubts about the former: “there be some who think that this herbe being carried aboute one, doth help

the falling sickness... which thing is vaine and superstitious.” However, he did affirm mullein’s value as a cough medicine.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Mullein is a valuable herb for coughs and congestion, and is a specific treatment for tracheitis and bronchitis. The leaves and the flowers may be used as an infusion to reduce mucus formation and stimulate the coughing up of phlegm. Mullein combines well with other expectorants such as coltsfoot (*Tussilago farfara*, p. 278) and thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143). Applied externally, mullein is emollient and makes a good wound healer. In Germany, the flowers are steeped in olive oil, and the resulting fixed oil is used as a remedy for ear infections and hemorrhoids.



Mullein is a good expectorant remedy for coughs and other chest problems.

Veronica officinalis (Scrophulariaceae) Speedwell

Description Creeping hairy perennial growing to 20 in (50 cm). Has oval leaves and darkly veined lilac flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation A common wild plant in Europe and North America, speedwell is most often found on heaths and in dry grassy places. It is picked in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Speedwell contains iridoid glycosides (including aucubin), acetopenone glucosides, and flavonoids (including apigenin and scutellarin).

History & Folklore Speedwell was formerly considered a useful diuretic and expectorant. It was much used to treat congestion, coughs and chronic skin conditions. It was also

given to counter nervous exhaustion due to excessive mental activity or concentration. However, in 1935, the French medicinal plant specialist Leclerc stated that “the infusion has no more virtue than the hot water used to prepare it.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Speedwell is now considered to have only a slight therapeutic effect. It is little used today.

Viburnum prunifolium (Caprifoliaceae) Black Haw

Description Deciduous shrub growing to 16 ft (5 m). Has serrated oval leaves, clusters of white flowers, and blue-black berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to central and southern North America, black haw grows in woodland. The branch bark is stripped in the spring or autumn, the root bark in the autumn only.

Parts Used Bark, root bark.

Constituents Black haw contains coumarins (including scopoletin and aesculetin), salicin, 1-methyl-2,3-dibutyl hemimellitate, viburnin, plant acids, a trace of volatile oil, and tannin.

History & Folklore The Catawba people used black haw bark to treat dysentery. In the 19th century, the bark was considered to be a uterine tonic, and a decoction was commonly used to help arrest hemorrhage of the uterus.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Black haw is antispasmodic and astringent, and is regarded as a specific treatment for menstrual pain. Echoing its 19th-century applications, the bark is also used to treat other gynecological conditions, such as prolapse of the uterus, heavy menopausal bleeding, morning sickness, and threatened miscarriage. Black haw’s antispasmodic property makes it of value in cases where colic or other cramping pain affects the bile ducts, the digestive tract, or the urinary tract.

Related Species The closely related *V. rufidulum* was used by the Menominee people to treat cramps and colic. See also cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150).

Caution People who are allergic to aspirin should not take black haw.

Self-help Use Period pain, p. 315.

Vinca minor (Apocynaceae) Lesser Periwinkle

Description A mainly ground-hugging evergreen shrub arching to 18 in (45 cm). Has rooting stems, shiny elliptical leaves, and 5-petaled, violet-blue flowers.